

Wire Fraud

Computer evidence examination and artifact analysis

Troy Hokanson

Sanitized case study. Adapted from my original forensic report. Names, dates, locations, account details and distinctive case facts are omitted. This is a newly written summary, not an original agency document.

Assignment and my role

I received a computer for examination in a wire-fraud investigation, accompanied by signed consent to search. I removed the internal hard drive and connected it through a write blocker. With another detective assisting, I created a forensic image using FTK Imager and secured the original evidence.

I examined the image using AccessData Forensic Toolkit (FTK) and Internet Evidence Finder (IEF), locating relevant email, browser and downloaded-file artifacts.

Finding 1: Payment instructions in email artifacts

I located emails containing bank-account instructions in the computer's paging file, a system file that can contain remnants of application data. I also located related webmail artifacts. These findings documented payment instructions relevant to the investigation and were bookmarked for the report. They did not, by themselves, prove that a transfer occurred or establish who controlled the receiving account.

Finding 2: Browser traces related to identity documents

I located browser-history entries containing filenames matching those printed on copies of suspected fraudulent identity documents. This connected the document filenames to webmail activity recorded on the examined computer. A filename match alone did not authenticate the documents or establish who created them.

Finding 3: Supporting communications and files

I located browser autofill information, downloaded photographs and search activity relevant to the inquiry. These artifacts supplied additional context for investigator review. I documented their locations and bookmarked responsive evidence rather than treating any single artifact as proof of the full fraud scheme.

Report and investigative contribution

I documented files directly related to the wire-fraud investigation and included bookmarked evidence in the forensic report. My report specified copies for the police case and a state fraud-investigation agency. This work supplied documented computer evidence for the broader investigation; it does not establish that I led the entire case or caused a particular outcome.